

Spiritual Maturity

This lesson is the tenth and final lesson in the series entitled “The Beginner’s Bible Study.” Other lessons in this series can be obtained through the Lehigh Valley Baptist Church.

The lessons are designed to be first studied, then the questions answered, and then reviewed with the help of an older Christian.

***“As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus
the Lord, so walk ye in Him.”
Colossians 2:6***

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I love babies! You probably do, too! They are so cute and cuddly and there is something awe-inspiring about bringing a new life into this world. Babies have very few needs and demands and within a loving family those needs are satisfied. Of course, babies continue to grow and go through stages of learning and developing and eventually will become independent adults, able to start their own families.

New Believers are Babies

God likens new believers to being “babies” in Christ. And there are many similarities. We will look at a few of these and then look ahead to see what areas of growth and development lie ahead and what exercises a new believer should be doing to strengthen himself spiritually.

Look up I Corinthians 13:11. *“When I was a _____, I spake as a _____, I understood as a _____”*

Hebrews 5:13-14 *“For every one that useth _____ is unskillful in the word of righteousness: for he is a _____”*

Ephesians 4:14-15 *“That we henceforth be no more _____, tossed to and fro, ... but speaking the truth in love, may _____ into him in all things, which is the head, even Christ.”*

Nourishment

The most basic and obvious need that a baby has is for nourishing milk. And that need must be met several times a day – every day. Likewise, the new convert needs spiritual food.

Look up I Peter 2:2. What does this verse say a new Christian should desire? _____

What will be the result of getting this “milk of the word”? _____

As you have worked through this series of lessons you have been given homework assignments to read specific passages of Scripture. Now that you have come to the end of the lessons, you need to have a plan for what you will be reading in the Bible. Hopefully by now you have acquired an appetite for daily reading of the Bible and have established a habit for a good time and quiet place to do that. One of the devil's most effective weapons to weaken a new Christian is to get him so busy or distracted that he puts off his daily time in God's word. Be alert to the tactics of the devil and make your daily Bible time your top priority.

Look up Ephesians 6:10-17

"...that ye may be able to stand against the _____ (methods) of the devil."

"And take... the sword of the Spirit, which is the _____"

How often did you read your Bible this past week? _____

What time and place works the best for you? _____

What hinders you the most from being in God's Word every day?

It would be good to review lesson 5 again about Spiritual Nourishment. There is no "one right way" to schedule your reading of the Bible. For new believers I recommend that you read through the New Testament two times over a course of several weeks or a few months. Then set a goal of reading through the entire Bible in one year. There are some reading schedules available from the church office. You might enjoy using one that has you reading some from the Old Testament and some from the New Testament every day.

As you read, keep an open notebook or journal handy to write down what God is teaching you. Do not focus on "trivia" but look for God's revelation of Himself to you. Look for promises to claim, commands to

obey, warnings to heed, doctrine to learn. Share with your teacher some of the things you are learning – it will be an encouragement to both of you!

Throughout this follow-up course you have been memorizing verses.

According to Psalm 119:11, why do we memorize God's Word?

Look up Psalm 119:105. What is another good reason for memorizing God's Word?

Just because this course is wrapping up, do not stop hiding God's Word in your heart. As you hear preaching and as you read the Bible daily, be looking for verses that are especially meaningful to you and then write them down on a card. Work at memorizing it over the course of a week. Keep reviewing verses you memorized previously.

We talk about the disciplines of the Christian life. All of us – not matter how recently or how long we have been saved – must be actively involved in these basics. The first one is daily Bible reading and memorization. The second one is prayer.

Prayer

Prayer in our spiritual walk is like crying, babbling, and learning to talk for a baby. We are communicating with our Father. He wants us to talk to him every day, and throughout the day. We ask for requests, but we also share our burdens and questions with Him. We seek His guidance and help.

Look up I Thess 5:17 How often should we pray? _____

Review lesson 6 about prayer. What are the four ingredients of our prayer life? (Remember the ACTS acrostic?) _____

Church Family

Recent studies have confirmed what our parents and grandparents knew to be true. Children raised in loving families will fare much better in life than children left to themselves, or put in day care, or raised in an orphanage. The interaction with siblings and parents, coupled with teaching and discipline, help shape and mold a child at each important stage of his growth and development.

Similarly, God has designed that when we are saved we should become part of the local body of believers. God did not intend for Christians to live on their own and fend for themselves. They should be part of their local church where they regularly hear God's Word taught, explained, and preached. We need to have "our toes stepped on" – the convicting work of the Holy Spirit in our personal lives – on a regular basis to keep us walking circumspectly. Remember how your brother or sister used to "tell on you" to mom and dad when you did something you shouldn't? And just that knowledge helped keep you out of some trouble I bet! So being accountable to the brothers and sisters in Christ at church helps us stay in God's will.

Look up Hebrews 10:24-25. "And let us consider one another to _____ unto _____ and _____. Not _____ the _____ of ourselves together, as the manner of some is; but _____ one another: and so much the more as ye see the day approaching."

It is vitally important for believers to be in church every service – Sunday morning, Sunday night, mid-week service. It takes three to thrive! Again, the devil knows that one of the surest ways to weaken a new believer is to keep him out of church so he will bring along every distraction and reason possible. It might be tiredness, fear of sickness "going around," favorite show on TV, school or work assignments that need to be done, etc. But beware – once you succumb to the temptation one time, it will be easier and easier to justify being out of church until you have weakened your spiritual life and miss more and more services.

Sunday school is another great opportunity for spiritual growth. It provides an opportunity to study God's Word in more depth, ask questions, share burdens and requests with other believers, and be accountable to brothers and sisters in Christ. What better way to start the Lord's Day than putting Him first on the week's agenda!

The three most basic disciplines of the Christian life are Bible reading, prayer, and church attendance. We never outgrow the need for these, just like a baby, child, teen, or adult needs food, fellowship, and family all their life. We call these "disciplines" though because it takes effort, time, and determination to include these habits in our busy schedules. Be alert to the tactics the devil uses in your life to try to side-track you in these three most basic and important areas of spiritual growth.

I Timothy 4:7 *"But refuse profane and old wives' fables, and _____ thyself rather unto _____."*

These may be the "basics" but we need to be reminded of them often in order to keep growing.

I Timothy 4:6 *"If thou put the brethren in _____ of these things, thou shalt be a good minister of Jesus Christ, _____ up in the _____ of _____ and of good _____..."*

Spiritual Maturity

But looking ahead toward spiritual maturity, there are a few more areas where you can begin to "work out," flex some spiritual muscles, and become more independent as an adult.

Look up these verses that talk about spiritual maturity:

Heb 5:13-14 *"But _____ _____ belongeth to them that are of _____, even those who by reason of use have their senses _____ to _____ both good and evil."*

I Corinthian 3:1-2 “And I, brethren, could not speak unto you as unto _____ but as unto _____, as unto _____ in Christ. I have fed you with _____ and not with _____: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it, neither yet now are ye able.”

Eph 4:13 “Till we all come ... unto a _____ man, unto the measure of the _____ of the _____ of Christ.”

Write out Ephesians 4:14 _____

In addition to Bible reading and listening to good preaching at church, it is important to become a “student of the Word.”

II Timothy 2:15 “_____ to show thyself approved unto God, a _____ than needeth not to be ashamed, _____ the _____ of _____.”

We have several resources at church here that you can use to grow in your spiritual understanding and discernment.

1. Review the lessons you have completed about assurance, baptism, Church membership, prayer, sin, and the Bible.
2. Purchase the ABC's of Christian Growth by Robert Sargeant and work through the lessons. Each letter of the alphabet corresponds to an important doctrine or teaching for Christians to learn about. The lesson format incorporates a lot of looking up Bible verses and answering questions. (The “W” lesson you did recently about “Witnessing” was from this book.)
3. Pastor Hammett wrote a series of Bible studies “*Walking with God.*” They are available from the church office.

4. In the bookstore are several topical Bible study books and books about doctrines, Baptist history, great biographies, Bible history and customs, and living the Christian life.
5. Ask Pastor or your teacher about lessons that have been written for specific areas of temptation from lust to fear and anger, and many other topics.
6. There are a number of different Study Bibles in the bookstore with charts, graphs, time-lines, explanations of Bible history and unfamiliar words.
7. Take a course in our Monday night Bible Institute. Though some of the students are training for future full-time service, many laymen (church members) take the classes just to learn their Bible better.

Dirty Diapers – Dealing with Sin

The unpleasant part of having babies is taking care of the messes they make! Remember the lessons you did recently about sin and temptation? God is continually working in your life to conform you to the image of Jesus. In order to do that, He will have to put His finger on sin in your life. It might start out with habits, actions, and words, but will soon focus on attitudes, motives, and more subtle heart issues. Look up these verses about God's working in your life in this area of correction.

Write out I John 1:9:

II Corinthians 5:17 "If any man be in Christ, he is a ____ :
 ____ are passed away; behold all things are become
 ____."

Read Hebrews 12:1-11. What is the Bible word here for discipline?

If we experience God’s chastening, it is proof we are His _____.

According to vss 10-11, what is the purpose of God’s chastening?

Phil 1:6 “Being confident of this very thing, that he which hath _____ a good work in you _____ it until the day of Jesus Christ.”

Read these passages and list in the two separate columns the works of the flesh, and the evidences that the Holy Spirit of God now indwells and controls you.

Galatians 5:19-25 and Colossians 3:8-10, 12-14

Flesh (to put off)	Spirit (put on the new man)

Reproduction

One of the very first things Jesus did with his new disciples was invite them to follow Him in bringing others to Christ.

Mark 1:17 “And Jesus said unto them, _____ ye after me, and I will _____ you to become _____ of _____.”

Read John 1:35-51

Jesus called Andrew to follow Him. Who did Andrew go find? (vs 41) _____ After Jesus called Philip (vs 43), who did Philip go find? (vs 45) _____

You recently completed the lesson about witnessing. Did you think of someone you and your teacher could do the Salvation Bible Study with? Once the study has been set up, you should get your own copy of the lessons and study them ahead of time. Then watch as your teacher goes through the lesson, making notes to yourself along the way. Learn how to use the Scripture diagrams to explain the plan of salvation. After you watch your teacher present the lessons, then switch roles, and you present the lessons while your teacher sits in to help mentor you.

Get involved in the evangelistic efforts of the church – weekly visitation, passing out gospel tracts, getting your testimony tract written and published. Learn more about Faith Promise – the means by which we support our missionaries financially. This is in addition to the tithe that we are commanded to give back to the Lord through His church.

Godly atmosphere

One more area that will help you keep your eyes on the Lord is to surround yourself with good music and good books. Our bookstore has many excellent resources. Biographies of great Christians and missionaries can strengthen your faith and be an encouragement to you. There are books about how to be a godly mother, father, wife, husband, teen, etc. Other

books cover “meatier” topics such as explaining other religions, or why we use the King James Version, or the history of the Baptists.

Serving the Lord

Finally, get involved in serving others through the ministries of the church. The local church is likened to a body, where every member has a different but important function. Under the direction of the Holy Spirit, each member can use the gifts and talents that God has given him. You can sing in the choir, help in the nursery or with the children’s ministries, or be an usher. After an interview and screening process, Pastor will match you to an area where you can use your spiritual gifts to glorify God by serving others.

Read Romans 12:4-8. What are the gifts that God gives to be used within the church body? _____

Also read I Corinthians 12:4—27 about the members of the church being like a body.

This series of Bible study lessons may have come to an end, but your Christian walk is just beginning!

Other studies are available if you want to continue.

Happy walking!